Soon the Embassy's two-mile-long procession of horses, camels and elephants found itself in 'sand-hills, rising one after another, like waves of the sea, and marked on the surface by the wind, like drifted snow . . . Off the road our horses sunk into the sand above the knees.'[31] Two weeks' hard trudge brought them through 'a tract of more than ordinary desolation, until we discovered the walls and towers of Bikaner, a great and magnificent city in the midst of a wilderness'.[32]

Beyond Bikaner lay the borders of Shuja's remaining Durrani dominions, and before long Elphinstone's party encountered their first Afghans – 'A party of one hundred and fifty soldiers on camels', lolloping through the empty desert towards them. 'There were two men on each camel, and each had a long and glittering matchlock.'[33] Soon after passing the Durrani stronghold of Dera Ismail Khan, Elphinstone received a welcoming letter and a dress of honour from Shuja, who sent a hundred cavalrymen, all 'dressed like Persians, with coloured clothes, boots, and low sheepskin caps'. By late February 1809 the Embassy had passed Kohat. In the distance rose the white snow peaks of Spin Garh; on the lower hills were the fortresses around which Elphinstone could see 'many marauders . . . but our baggage was too well guarded to allow of their attacking it', forcing the predatory tribesmen to sit watching, 'looking wistfully at the camels passing'.

Here the valleys were as benign and inviting as the hills were wild. The Embassy passed along straight avenues of poplar and mulberry, criss-crossed by streams and bridged with arches of thin Mughal brickwork shaded with tamarisks. Occasionally they saw a hunting party, where the men had hawks on their fists and pointers at their heels, or groups of fowlers out to catch quails or partridges. Soon the British emissaries found themselves passing walled gardens full of familiar plants: 'wild raspberry and blackberry bushes . . . plum and peach trees, weeping willows and plane trees in leaf'. Even the birds brought back memories of home: 'some of the gentlemen thought they saw and heard thrushes and blackbirds'.[34]

Peshawar was at that time 'large, very populous and opulent'. It was the winter capital of Durrani Afghanistan as well as being a major centre of Pashtun culture.[35] Within the last century it had been the base of the two greatest Pashtun poets, both of whom Elphinstone had read. Rehman Baba was the great Sufi poet of the Pashtun language, the Rumi of the Frontier. 'Sow flowers, so your surroundings become a garden,' he wrote. 'Don't